



The wall of skulls at the Templo Mayor archaeological site in Mexico City is made from skulls carved in stone, covered with stucco; the Aztecs practised human sacrifice at the vast temples in the centre of Tenochtitlan.

**FOUNDED BY THE AZTECS IN 1325**, the city of **Tenochtitlan**—existing on the apparently unpromising site of a marshy island in a partially brackish lake—reached its height at the beginning of the 15th century. Tenochtitlan means “Place of the Fruit of the Cactus”—a reference to the vision that supposedly informed the choice of location. In this vision, the tossed heart of a conquered enemy landed on the island where an eagle wrestled with a snake on a cactus growing out of a rock—as depicted on the present-day Mexican flag. The **Aztecs** drained the island, reclaiming surrounding land, and joined the land together with causeways.

Meanwhile, they expanded their political territory through marriages, alliances, and conquest. After a flood, Tenochtitlan was laid out on a grid pattern, with quarters arranged around a **central sacred district**, regarded as the center of the world. A huge population of up to 200,000 was supported by **intensive agriculture** and extensive **networks of trade** and tribute.

The African **Songhay kingdom** was centered on the trading metropolis of Gao, in the Niger Bend area of **West Africa**. Gao had long been a prosperous city thanks to interregional and trans-Saharan trade with the

Islamic world, especially in salt, gold, slaves, and ivory. In the mid-13th century, because of the allure of its riches, it became an eastern province of the **Mali Empire** (see 1231–35). However, in the early



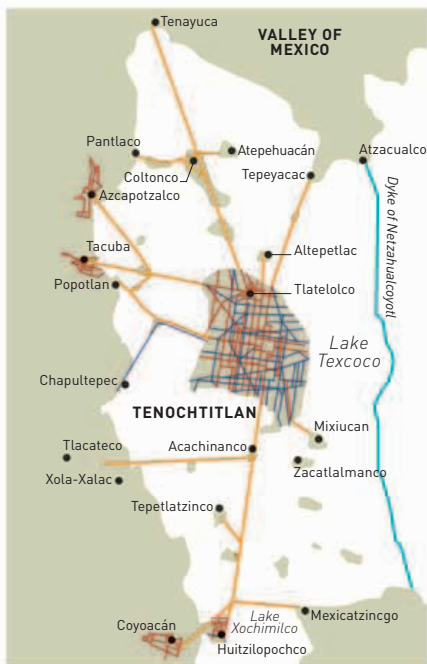
**Songhay gold coin**

*This coin from the Songhay Empire is from the Songhay city of Gao; rich and powerful, the city provided the basis for building the empire.*

15th century, Mali declined and Gao won its independence, beginning the growth of a Songhay Empire that would eclipse the other two largest empires of the late Iron Age in West Africa—Ghana and Mali.

In 1398, **Timur Leng** (see 1356–65) had invaded northern India and destroyed the **Delhi sultanate** with astonishing speed and terrifying cruelty. Marching 160 miles (260km) in two days, he captured and massacred 100,000 fugitives outside Delhi before sacking the city, supposedly building a huge pyramid from the skulls of his victims. In 1401, Timur massacred the population of Baghdad and launched an invasion of Syria. He then moved against the **Ottomans** (see 1286–90), occupying Anatolia and restoring the old Turkoman principalities.

**Map of Tenochtitlan**  
Causeways connected Tenochtitlan to other settlements on the lake and the mainland. The city and its emperor dominated the Valley of Mexico.



**KEY**  
— street  
— aqueduct  
— causeway  
— dyke

“WE HAVE **SET EYES ON... REGIONS... FAR AWAY...**”

Zheng He, Chinese explorer

**HAVING CONQUERED AS FAR AS RUSSIA** in the East, **Timur Leng** (see 1386–90) set his sights on the greatest empire—**China**. In 1405, he embarked on a campaign, but died en route to China and was buried at his capital, Samarkand. Despite his possibly exaggerated reputation for cruelty, Timur was a devout Muslim and a **patron of the arts** and architecture. His enormous empire did not long survive him, quickly breaking down into a Timurid state ruled by his son Shah Rukh (1377–1447), which soon fragmented further.

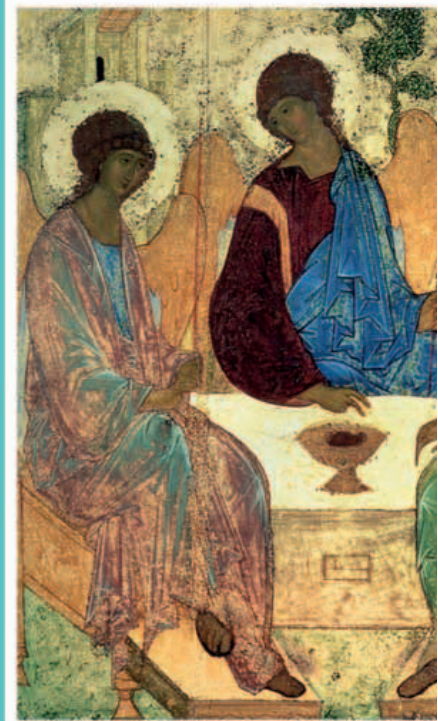
In 1404, John the Fearless (1371–1419) became **duke of Burgundy**, leading opposition to the regency of Louis, duke of Orleans (1372–1407), brother of the mad king, Charles VI of France (1368–1422). In 1407, John ordered the assassination of Louis, triggering **civil war** between the Burgundians and the Armagnacs (named for the count of Armagnac, the father-in-law of Charles, the new duke of Orleans). The **Burgundians**, who favored peace with the English, were popular in Paris and the north, while the **Armagnacs**, who were anti-English and pro-war, had the support of Queen Isabeau of Bavaria, the great nobles, and the south of the country.

In 1404, **Zheng He** (1371–1435)—a Muslim captured from Yunnan in China as a boy, castrated, and pressed into military service—was named grand, or high-ranking, eunuch at the imperial court. The following year he led the first of seven epic voyages of discovery.



Wladyslaw II Jagiello of Poland prepares for the Battle of Tannenberg.

**THE RELENTLESS ADVANCE OF THE ORDER OF TEUTONIC KNIGHTS** (see 1236–40) had brought Prussia and much of the Baltic coast under their control, cutting Poland off from the sea. The union of Poland and Lithuania under King Wladyslaw II Jagiello (c. 1362–1434) posed a new threat to the Order, and the **Great Northern War** ensued. At the **Battle of Tannenberg** in 1410—one of the greatest cavalry confrontations of the age—a huge Polish–Lithuanian army of up to 16,500, including Bohemian mercenaries, Russians, and even Tatars (Turkic Mongols), defeated



c. 1400s Height of Aztec city of Tenochtitlan

c. 1400s Expansion of West African Songhay Empire

1401 Timur (1336–1405) massacres population of Baghdad

1402 Italian architect Lorenzo Ghiberti commissioned to design doors of Florence Baptistery

1402 Battle of Ankara; Timur captures Ottoman sultan

1403 Malay ruler Parameswara establishes Sultanate of Malacca

1405 Breakup of Visconti domains; Venice seizes Padua, Verona, and Vicenza

1405 First voyage of explorer Zheng He

1405 Death of Timur (b. 1336); fragmentation of Timurid Empire

1407 Civil war in France pits Armagnacs against Burgundians

1409 Donatello di Niccolò di Bernardo Barti completes his masterpiece, David

1409 Council of Pisa results in three papal claimants